DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Are We Led Where We Want to Go?

Derech Hashem 2:3:4-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 3, end of paragraph 3, paragraph 4 and the start of paragraph 5 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 20 May 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: the role we are given

Before Shavuot the class learned "half a reason" why righteous people may struggle materially while wicked people prosper. Hashem must create an imbalance in the world: each of us has an individual role, and some must be born wealthy and some poor, some healthy and some not. Asking why this person is wealthy and that one poor is, the Rabbi said, like asking why the sky is blue and not green. The Rambam says you cannot ask that, because if it were green you would ask why it is green. There has to be an imbalance.

He reread the end of paragraph 3: Hashem determines what is best for each individual, the situation in which that person is most likely to succeed, given his character and abilities. "Ultimately it has to be a challenge, and ultimately Hashem wants us to win. So I'm going to give you the best tools possible, but you have to do it yourself." Only Hashem knows the calculation.

Paragraph 4: the path a person chooses

Now a new explanation, built on an important principle of Hazal: "In the way a person wishes to go, he is led." If you want to go on the path of wickedness, Hashem sometimes allows you and even helps you; sometimes He blocks you.

The Ramhal says Hashem decreed that a person's actions themselves have consequences: a person can make his own path easier and protect himself from further stumbling. "He guards the feet of His pious ones." The more committed you are to serving Hashem, the fewer obstacles there will be.

There are many levels. By strict judgment of what he has done, one person receives some help, another a great deal. And the reverse: one person is neither helped nor hindered. "He's a real beinoni... I'm not going to help him do bad. I'm not going to help him do good either." Another, because of his past actions, will need great toil to reach perfection. And someone may be so wicked that he is completely blocked from it.

Pharaoh and addiction

Who in Tanakh was blocked from reaching perfection? Pharaoh. Everyone asks where his free will was, when the Torah says Hashem hardened his heart. There are different answers, and the Rabbi called the Rambam's the simplest: Pharaoh put himself in that situation.

He compared it to addiction. Suppose a person becomes so addicted to nicotine that on Shabbat he can no longer control himself, is warned, and smokes. Is he liable? Of course, because he put himself in that situation.

Similarly, the verse in Parashat Kedoshim says, "Do not deny falsely and do not lie." Why both? Because first you deny, freely. But then, caught in that lie, you must weave a whole web of lies to protect it, until sometimes there is no way out. You are still responsible, because you chose to start. So too Pharaoh: he no longer had free will at the end, but he is punished because he brought himself there. In the same way a person can become so wicked that Hashem blocks his ability to do teshuvah. The point is that "your actions can generate Hashem's assistance, or reluctance to assist, and even prevention."

Blessings as tools

The Ramhal adds that a person may be given material success to help him serve Hashem and reach perfection more easily. The Rabbi said this echoes the Rambam in Hilchot Teshuvah. The Rambam asks: we have learned that there is no reward in this world, so what are all the blessings in Behukkotai, read the week before, "if you walk in My ways I will give you rain in its season..."? The Rambam answers that these are not reward. Because you have taken a step in the right direction, Hashem makes it possible for you to reach perfection. You cannot do that if you are busy working all day, so He gives you the financial means to devote yourself to wisdom. Or you have a passion to run great hesed organisations but lack the time and money, and He provides them. "All the berakhot in the Torah are only berakhot to enable you to achieve perfection."

This answers a question a participant had asked weeks earlier: why does a righteous person sometimes have everything good? Because Hashem sees he can become even more perfect.

The converse also applies. A righteous person may have things taken away because Hashem wants him to work harder and break through a wall. A rasha may be given success that opens the way to his own destruction, or may meet hard times that stop his plans from coming to fruition.

More is expected of the comfortable

The Ramhal says Hashem does all this in His great wisdom for the good of His creatures, and takes all of it into account when deciding a person's reward. Someone materially successful, healthy and wealthy, who still does not give his all to Hashem, will not have the same reward as someone in a difficult situation who, under pressure, still completes his work.

"This is really interesting," said the Rabbi. You might think it is better to be wealthy, with a free mind to serve Hashem, without worrying about parnasah or health. True, but the downside is that much more is expected of you. The one whose default is very difficult, if he makes it, ends

up higher. Why one gets this and another that is "literally infinite," and "My thoughts are not your thoughts."

Three answers so far

The Rabbi counted the explanations for why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper:

1. Sufferings that cleanse a person of his few sins (and worldly reward that repays the wicked for their few good deeds).
2. This is your role: the situation in which you are meant to serve Hashem.
3. Hashem sometimes gives success to help you on your chosen path, or difficulty to block it, for good or for bad.

"That's why you can't make a decision for anyone, because there's so many variables."

Paragraph 5: suffering that wakes us up

The Ramhal then gives a fourth explanation. A person may be decent overall but have some sins he is not working on. Hashem wants to wake him up, so he is made to suffer so that he becomes more careful in his deeds.

This is quite different from the first explanation. That was suffering to cleanse; this is suffering to awaken. The analogy is a person who has fainted: you shake him, not to hurt him, but so he comes to. "Yeah, you're good all in all, but you've got problems. You're not dealing with them. I'm going to shake you up to wake you up." This is the Gemara in Berakhot: one who sees suffering coming upon him should examine his deeds, and if he finds nothing, attribute it to neglect of Torah study.

A participant asked how this differs from the first kind, since in both cases a mostly righteous person suffers. The Rabbi agreed with the participant's suggestion: here the purification comes from the person changing himself, perhaps through lighter suffering to see whether he will repent, and if he does, he is fine. "You need to be given four as an opportunity before you just get whacked with one." That, he said, is exactly what the Ramhal says in the next lines.

Summary

- Each person is placed in the situation in which he is most likely to succeed, though only Hashem knows the calculation.
- "In the way a person wishes to go, he is led": our choices bring more help, no help, or even obstacles, as with Pharaoh.
- The blessings of the Torah are tools to help us reach perfection, not payment.
- More is expected of those given comfort, and one who succeeds through hardship may rise higher.
- A fourth answer to the suffering of the righteous: suffering that wakes a person up to teshuvah, given before suffering that cleanses.

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